

FINANCE SECRETARY ASHOK CHAWLA (CENTRE) AT THE LAUNCH OF E-FILING FACILITY OF THE FOREIGN INVESTMENT PROMOTION BOARD

ating the entire hospital information system. The system will connect 1,200 dispensaries, 400 hospitals and 100 offices, provide the insured people with cards and create electronic health records. "After completion, the project will have 30,000-40,000 users and 2.4 crore IT insured people, the largest covered area in the world," he says.

TCS has embarked on Passport Seva. The Rs 1,000-crore project would automate passport issuance for citizens and deliver them within three days of application. There is also a Tatkal scheme where the passport would be delivered in a day. "In the beginning, over six million passports will be issued by the system every year and it will go on to approximately 14 million by the sixth year of the contract," says Tanmoy Chakrabarty, vice-president, public service, TCS. The company has already established its reputation for citizen service delivery excellence with the completion of Corporate Affairs Ministry's MCA21 project. The project is today facilitating better administration of companies by enabling 100 per cent electronic filing, electronic payment mechanisms, and use of digital signature certificates for all transactions.

Not to be left behind, Infosys is focusing on quality to design and implement power reforms in Karnataka to cut transmission losses, as well as in the Orissa Power Transmission Corporation's programme of implementa-

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tion of Smart Grids. However, it is the eBiz Project awarded by the Ministry of Commerce and Industry which it considers an achievement. The high-end task involves designing and developing an eBiz platform to develop a conducive business environment in India and provide the business community speedy access to information and services.

The focus for Bajwa is on accelerating the pace of government projects which he feels have been very slow, particularly in the Department of Posts. Microsoft India is spearheading Project Arrow, involving the phase-wise adoption of IT in making retail counters more efficient and cutting down on the delivery time of mail. In states like Gujarat, Microsoft has diversified to providing easier access to next-generation Microsoft tools and technologies for faculty and university students to help the latter improve their career prospects. In Uttarakhand, it is promoting computer literacy in Hindi by offering a Windows XP Starter Edition PC and other versions with Intel processors at easy installments.

Sandeep Raina, senior vice-president for Government, Cisco, a company which gets 30-35 per cent of the Government spend on IT projects, feels that the returns from working on

projects like SWAN are higher as well as satisfying. He has been driving Cisco's e-learning initiative with the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) to introduce the ICT curriculum in six selected Accredited Vocational Institutes (AVIs) in Ambala, Bhopal, Balangir (Orissa), Delhi, Mumbai and Shillong. These institutes aim at providing hardware and networking courses to prepare students for IT-related careers.

Oracle has tapped a future growth driver in e-governance, the yet to be exploited financial inclusion arena. Under this scheme, 28,000 Common Service Centres (cscs), powered by Oracle and set up by Sahaj, a subsidiary of Srei Infrastructure, will take banking services to the people. Accounts opened with the State Bank of India under the SBI-Sahaj partnership will help those benefitting from the NREGA scheme in the remotest parts of the country to manage their earnings. The Oracle powered cscs have already reached 80,000 students with their e-learning projects.

This is just the beginning of a Westside story going desi with areas like internal security and defence set to unleash a bouquet of opportunities. What it translates into for the IT companies is replenished coffers, for the government transparency in service delivery, and for the *aam aadmi* services at low cost. It's a win-win situation for all.

INDIA'S FIRST SUCCESSFUL PROJECT MCA21, COMPLETED BY TCS, IN FULL SWING IN DELHI

